Lesson 30: Narrative Paragraphs 1: Focus, Topic Sentence, Time Order and Past Tenses

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 3: Verb Tenses and Narration · The Human Lifespan

Adapted from Building Academic Writing Skills by Lin Cui, Harper College (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0): Unit 5 Narrative Paragraphs, sections I. Warm-Up to V. Past Tenses in Narration.

In this lesson

This is the first of two lessons on narrative paragraphs, which tell a story. With student paragraphs as models, you will study how a narrative begins, how its events are put in time order with time transitions, and how past tenses are used. Then you will plan your own story. Telling events clearly and in order is also needed in reflective writing and in describing a study or a case.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Explain what a narrative paragraph focuses on and recognize narrative titles.
- Write a topic sentence with a controlling idea and background information in one to three sentences.
- Arrange events in chronological order and use time transitions with correct punctuation.
- Use past tenses to narrate, and explain when a writer changes to another tense.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
narration	a description of an experience, an event, a story or a situation to show a point of view	"My Worst Trip" is a narrative paragraph.
controlling idea	the word or idea in the topic sentence that shows the writer's point of view on the topic	My experiences at Miami Airport ... were **terrible** ...
background information	what the reader needs first: what, who, when, where (and why, how if applicable)	I came from Mexico, and that was my first connecting trip out of my own country.
chronological order	time order: what happened first is written first	One month before the interview, I read the book.
time transition	a word, phrase, clause or sentence that guides the reader through time	As soon as my name was called, I took a deep breath.
despondent (adjective)	feeling sad and hopeless (book)	I just stayed in my seat quietly and felt despondent.
a rocky start (noun phrase)	not a smooth beginning (book)	I had just had a rocky start on my life in this new country.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
superficially (adverb)	on the surface, not deeply (book)	I understood the topic only superficially.
elaborately (adverb)	with great care and effort (book)	It is important to prepare elaborately before an important event.
transform (verb)	change in significant ways (book)	Our meeting transformed my whole life.

Rules and explanations

What a narrative paragraph is

A narrative paragraph tells a story to show a point of view; it does not argue or list points like the enumerative paragraphs of Unit 2. It has **a beginning** (How did the story start?), **a middle** (How did it progress?) and **an ending** (How did it end?). Give the **background information** (what, who, when, where; why and how if applicable) at the beginning, use **past tenses**, use **time expressions** in **chronological order**, and use descriptive words and details (Lesson 31).

The beginning: topic sentence and background information

The beginning is the topic sentence (topic + controlling idea) and the background information, in one to three sentences. The book's model: what: a shopping trip · controlling idea: exhausting · who: my sister and I · when: Black Friday, 2019 · where: Woodfield Mall · why: to get good deals on Christmas gifts for family and friends.

- **3 sentences:** My sister and I had an exhausting shopping trip in the Woodfield Mall. It was Black Friday, 2019. We wanted to get good deals on Christmas gifts for our family and friends.
- **2 sentences:** On Black Friday in 2019, my sister and I had an exhausting shopping trip in the Woodfield Mall. We wanted to get good deals on Christmas gifts for our family and friends.
- **1 sentence:** To get good deals on Christmas gifts for our family and friends, my sister and I had an exhausting shopping trip in the Woodfield Mall on Black Friday in 2019.

The middle: chronological order

The middle is the main part of the story: what happened first is written first, what happened next comes next. Draw a **timeline** (the events on a line in time order) before you write and use it as your outline. "My Memorable Interview" follows one: read the book → bought a second book → flew to the college → the interview → flew back home.

Time transitions and their punctuation

Type	Examples	Punctuation
Adverbs	First, Next, Meanwhile, Then, Finally, Lastly	at the start of a sentence: comma after them (*Then*: usually no comma)

Type	Examples	Punctuation
Other adverbs and adverbial phrases	Right away, Suddenly, Soon, Moments later, Subsequently, That morning, The following day	at the start: comma; at the end of a sentence: no comma
Prepositional phrases	At first, At last, After that, After a while, In the meantime, At noon, In the morning	at the start: comma; at the end: no comma
Dependent clauses (subject + verb, but not a full sentence)	When I woke up, While I was driving, As soon as they arrived home, After the test was over	before the main clause: comma; after it: no comma
Complete sentences	Time went by quickly. Misfortune goes hand in hand. (= Bad things happen one after another.) Two hours passed.	a period after them

The book underlines the time transitions in "My Memorable Interview", for example: *One month before the interview, / The interview day arrived. / As soon as my name was called, / During the interview, / That afternoon,* and *then* with no comma (I then bought another book).

Past tenses in narration

Use mostly past tenses, above all the simple past. Present and future tenses are possible in some parts.

Tense	Use in a story	Example from the models
simple past	the main events	After a long flight from my native country, I arrived at Miami Airport.
past progressive (was/were + -ing)	an action in progress at that time	I was not walking excitedly anymore ...
past perfect (had + past participle)	an action before another past time	I had not eaten much on my first flight.
past perfect progressive (had been + -ing)	an action that continued up to a past time	Our family had been waiting for her arrival for a long time.
future in the past (would + verb; the book's "future past")	the future seen from a past moment	I made a promise to myself that I would have to study English really hard.
present, present perfect	the writer's lesson or view now, often at the end	From this experience, I have learned a lesson essential to my success.

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Arabic stories often join many events with "and" in one long sentence. In English, use separate sentences connected with time transitions (*Suddenly, ... After that,* ...), not a long chain of "and ... and ... and".

Practice

1. Warm-up: "My Worst Trip". Read the paragraph in your lesson material and label its parts (the book color codes them). Find: a) the topic sentence; b) the background information; c) the sentence where the story begins; d) the sentence where the end of the story begins; e) the concluding sentence(s); f) the time transitions. Then answer: Does the writer focus on telling a story, arguing for a controversial issue, or listing points to explain an idea?

2. Exercise 1: Narrative titles. Write T (an appropriate narrative title) or F (not a narrative title).

1. My First Day at Harper College
2. Attending My Best Friend's Wedding
3. My Dream House
4. How to Register for Online Classes
5. Reasons for Taking a Yoga Class
6. My First Black Friday Shopping Trip
7. A Memorable Morning at the Beach
8. Different Types of Friends

3. Exercise 2: Plan the beginning. For each topic, fill in the controlling idea, who, when, where, why and how (if applicable), as in the shopping-trip model. Then write the beginning in one, two or three sentences.

1. My first visit to Harper College (or to your own college)
2. My family's most important day

4. Exercise 3: "The Day My Daughter Was Born". Read the paragraph in your lesson material.

1. What is the topic sentence? What is the controlling idea?
2. What is the background information (what, who, when, where, why)?
3. Does the paragraph follow chronological order?
4. Find the time transitions at the start of sentences. What punctuation follows them?

5. "A Significant Meeting". Read the paragraph in your lesson material. The online book prints eight verbs in bold: six in the past perfect, one in the past progressive and one in the simple future. Find them and say why the writer used each tense.

6. Exercise 4: "Meeting My Best Friends". Write the correct tense of the verb in brackets. (This is the beginning and the end of the paragraph. More items: lesson material, Exercise 4. Your tutor can check them.)

I still feel (feel) excited when I remember the day I (1) _____ (meet) my best friends. It (2) _____ (be) spring 2013. At that time, my family and I (3) _____ (live) in an apartment building in a town by a small airport. That day, I (4) _____ (walk) outside with my daughter. Then, I (5) _____ (see) a woman and a man moving their furniture into the building. At first, I (6) _____ (think) they (7) _____ (be) Russian because I (8) _____ (hear) the man speak in the Russian language. Both of them (9) _____ (be) tall and about 30-35 years old. She (10)

_____ (have) blonde hair and green eyes. He (11) _____ (have) dark hair. [...] It (12) _____ (be) almost ten years since we first (13) _____ (meet). I (14) _____ (be) very grateful to that day because I (15) _____ (meet) my best friends.

Speak with your tutor

- "Ask me about a memorable day in my life: what, who, when, where and why. Then help me write a topic sentence with a clear controlling idea."
- "I will tell you a short story from my life in the past tense. Then list my tense mistakes and the time transitions I used."
- "Check my answers to all the blanks of Exercise 4 in the lesson material."

Read aloud

Past tense *-ed* endings: /t/ after voiceless sounds, /d/ after voiced sounds, /ɪd/ after /t/ and /d/.

1. After a long flight from my native country, I arrived /d/ at Miami Airport.
2. I went to a small restaurant in the airport, looked /t/ at the pictures of the menu on the screen, and decided /ɪd/ to have a coke and a sandwich.
3. They comforted /ɪd/ me, "Don't worry. All will be fine."

Writing task

Plan your own story (Exercise 2, #3): a past experience with a clear point of view, for example a frightening, funny or important day.

1. Fill in the table: topic, controlling idea, who, when, where, why, how.
2. Write the beginning in one, two and three sentences; choose the best version.
3. Draw a timeline of six to ten events.
4. Write the middle of the story (120 to 180 words) from your timeline, mainly in the simple past, with at least five different time transitions.

Self-editing checklist:

1. Does my topic sentence have a clear controlling idea?
2. Does my beginning give what, who, when and where?
3. Are the events in chronological order?
4. Did I use different types of time transitions, with a comma after each one at the start of a sentence?
5. Did I use the simple past for the main events and the past perfect for earlier events?
6. Did I write separate sentences instead of a long chain of "and ... and"?

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it. Keep this work: in Lesson 31 you can develop it into a full narrative paragraph.

Answer key

1. Warm-up

- a) "My experiences at Miami Airport ... were terrible because I could not understand English." b) "I came from Mexico, and that was my first connecting trip out of my own country." (a and b: book, section III)
- c) "After a long flight from my native country, I arrived at Miami Airport." d) "In the end, I met my family at the airport in Chicago at 11:30 pm." e) The last two sentences ("However, I could not shake off the feeling ..." and "On that day, I made a promise ..."). The border between parts can differ a little; the middle (Miami Airport and the plane) is the longest part.
- f) After a long flight from my native country, / until a uniformed officer asked me ... / Suddenly, / Finally, / in the evening / In the end, / On our way home, / On that day,
- It focuses on telling a story.

2. Exercise 1 (book): 1 T, 2 T, 3 F, 4 F, 5 F, 6 T, 7 T, 8 F.

3. Exercise 2 (example answer)

1. Confusing; my cousin and I; August 2023; the college campus; to register for English classes. *My first visit to Harper College in August 2023 was confusing because the campus was so big. My cousin and I went there to register for English classes.*
2. Unforgettable; my parents, my sisters and I; June 2019; a university in Cairo; my brother's graduation. *My brother's graduation day in June 2019 was my family's most important day. My parents, my sisters and I traveled to Cairo to see him become the first university graduate in our family.*

4. Exercise 3

1. "The day I met my daughter Ela has been the most significant day in my life." Controlling idea: the most significant day.
2. What: the day her daughter Ela was born. Who: the writer, her husband, the doctor. When: in her 38th week of pregnancy. Where: the hospital. Why: a routine pre-natal exam.
3. Yes: the exam, the doctor's news, the tests, the surgery, waking up, her room, meeting Ela, her promise.
4. Dependent clauses: *When I was in my 38th week of pregnancy, / While the doctor was checking me, / When I opened my eyes,* · adverbs: *Right away, / Soon,* · prepositional phrases: *Upon hearing this, / In the next ten minutes, / After that, / At that moment,*. A comma follows each one.

5. "A Significant Meeting" (the bold verbs: book; the reasons: not from the book)

- Past perfect: *had communicated*, *had planned*, *had overslept*, *had gotten*, *had remembered*, *had decided*: actions that happened before other past events or before a past time (*By the end of our first day together, I had decided ...*).
- Past progressive: *was wearing*: what Sergey was wearing at the moment she saw him (an action in progress at that time).

- Simple future: *will remain*: the writer speaks from the present about the future.

6. Exercise 4 (book): 1 met, 2 was, 3 were living (*lived* is also correct), 4 was walking, 5 saw, 6 thought, 7 were, 8 heard, 9 were, 10 had, 11 had, 12 has been, 13 met, 14 am, 15 met.

My notes